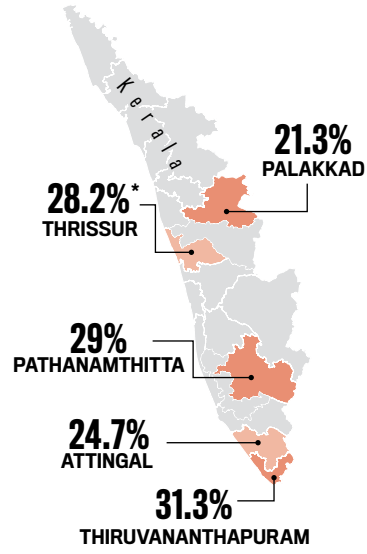
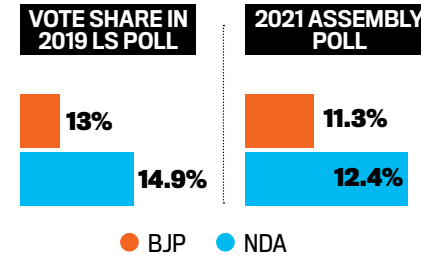
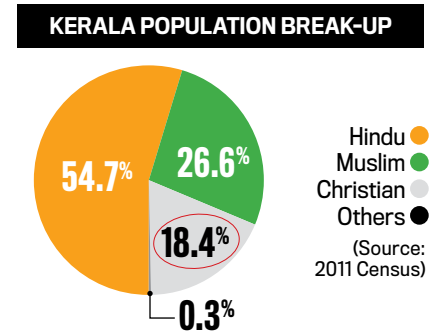
BJP FOCUS ON FIVE LS CONSTITUENCIES



*BJP vote share in 2019 LS poll





BJP," he said, explaining why Kerala's Muslims and Christians will keep their distance from the saffron party.

But the BJP's ambitions are clear. Ten days later, on March 12, Union home minister Amit Shah was in Thrissur in central Kerala to flag off a 'Janshakti Yatra' where he also let on that they were focusing on winning five seats from the state in the 2024 general election. Critical to that will be the Christians, who account for 18.4 per cent of the state's population. The five Lok Sabha constituencies being targeted are those where the BJP got the maximum vote share—Thiruvananthapuram, Pathanamthitta, Thrissur, Attingal and Palakkad. All five have above 60 per cent Hindu concentration and a considerable Christian presence (especially the first three), enough to ensure victories if support from the latter materialises.

Track icon and the party-nominated Rajya Sabha member P.T. Usha could be nominated from one of these seats. In Thrissur, Mollywood superstar Suresh Gopi is most likely to contest again considering his fine performance in 2019. In fact, the Janshakti rally Shah attended was organised by Gopi.

The BJP believes a visit by Pope Francis to India and, of course, Kerala, before the 2024 election could boost ties with the Catholic community, who make up 61 per cent of the 6.4 million Christians in the state. The BJP central leadership has established links with Catholic Bishops' Conference in India (CBCI) president Archbishop Andrews Thazhathu, who hails from Thrissur, and the heads of the Syro-Malabar Church (Cardinal George Alencherry) and Syro-Malankara Church (Cardinal Basilios Cleemis) as well as senior Latin Catholic Church bishops.

The BJP-led NDA performed well by its own standards in Kerala in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls, even coming in second in the Thiruvananthapuram seat with BJP veteran Kummanam Rajasekharan winning 31.3 per cent of the popular vote. The party benefitted from issues such as the protests over the entry of women in the Sabarimala temple and the resulting Hindu consolidation.



"THE RESULTS IN GOA AND THE NORTHEAST STATES SHOW THAT THE CHRISTIAN BROTHERS ARE WITH THE BJP"

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister and BJP leader

The gains from 2019, though, were lost by the time the 2021 assembly polls came around. Still, state BJP chief K. Surendran seems full of gumption. "We are confident of winning a few Lok Sabha seats from Kerala. The good governance practices of the Modi regime have impressed Keralites. Compare that to the muddle the Pinarayi government is in. New revelations in the gold smuggling scandal continue to embarrass the CM, and now there are allegations of corruption over the fire at the Brahmapuram waste treatment plant in Kochi. They have not been able to douse the fire even after 12 days. Keralites are waiting for 2024 to show the corrupt Marxists and the politically irrelevant Congress their place," Surendran told INDIA TODAY.

Addressing BJP workers in Thrissur, Shah listed the Modi government's efforts to aid Kerala's development: "The Congress-led UPA government allocated just Rs 45,900 crore as tax devolution from 2009-14 whereas the Modi regime has offered Rs 1.15 lakh crore to Kerala. Under the MNREGA scheme, we provided Rs 8,500 crore to the state. We also sanctioned Rs 317 crore for the Guruvayur temple, Rs 1,950 crore for the Kochi Metro second stage and cleared assistance for a 50 MW solar plant in Kasaragod."

For the past decade or so, the state BJP has boasted of a strong network (it claims around 2 million workers now), but its vote share has hovered around the 10-13 per cent mark. Its function has been mostly as 'vote-splitter' and it has won an assembly seat only once—in 2016, when veteran leader O. Rajagopal was elected from Nemom in Thiruvananthapuram district. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has in its ranks the Ezhava political outfit Bharath Dharma Jana Sena and the Kerala Congress (P.C. Thomas) group